

Notes: Durante, Pinotti, and Tesei (AER, 2019)
The Political Legacy of Entertainment TV

Contents

1	Big picture	3
2	Incremental contribution of the paper	3
3	Institutional background and data	4
3.1	The rise of Mediaset	4
3.2	Mediaset content versus RAI content	4
3.3	Political setting	5
3.4	Signal-strength data	5
3.5	Individual-level mechanism data	6
4	Empirical specifications and identification	6
4.1	Baseline municipality specification	6
4.2	Balance and pre-trend logic	6
4.3	Robustness designs	7
4.4	Individual-level specifications	7
5	Main results and interpretation	8
5.1	Early Mediaset exposure and <i>Forza Italia</i> in 1994	8
5.2	Persistence and the shift to M5S	8
5.3	Populist attitudes, not generic right-wing values	8
5.4	Age heterogeneity	9
5.5	Mechanisms for children	9
5.6	Mechanisms for older viewers	9
5.7	Why populist parties benefit	9
6	Tables and figures	10
6.1	Figure 1: Total airtime and content categories	10
6.2	Figure 2: Movie quality and parental suitability	10

6.3	Figure 3: Timeline of events	11
6.4	Figure 4: Actual and hypothetical signal strength	11
6.5	Table 1: Balance tests using pre-1994 voting	12
6.6	Table 2: Balance tests using municipality characteristics	12
6.7	Table 3: Baseline effect on <i>Forza Italia</i> in 1994	13
6.8	Table 4: Robustness for 1994 results	13
6.9	Figure 5: Robustness graphically	14
6.10	Table 5: Main parties and elections, 1994–2013	14
6.11	Table 6: Political attitudes	15
6.12	Figure 6: TV consumption and age-specific effects	15
6.13	Table 7: Child exposure and military cognition outcomes	16
6.14	Table 8: Age-specific mechanisms	16
6.15	Figure 7: Robustness for individual-level outcomes	17
6.16	Figure 8: Education, civic engagement, and party support	17
6.17	Table 9: Readability of party manifestos and TV debates	18
6.18	Table 10: Opinions about Berlusconi	18
7	Short summary	19
8	Conclusion	20
8.1	Core conclusion	20
8.2	Economic intuition	20
8.3	Incremental contribution revisited	20
8.4	Implications	20
8.5	Limitations	20
8.6	Takeaway	21

1 Big picture

- **Question.** Can non-news entertainment television have persistent political effects? The paper asks whether early exposure to Silvio Berlusconi’s commercial TV network, Mediaset, changed voting behavior and political attitudes in Italy.
- **Core contrast.** Existing media-and-politics research usually studies biased news. This paper studies light entertainment content: movies, variety shows, and other non-informational programming aired before Mediaset introduced news broadcasts.
- **Setting.** Italy in the 1980s provides a useful setting because private commercial television expanded gradually across municipalities. Some places received Mediaset before 1985, while others received it later.
- **Why content is identifiable.** During the early rollout, Mediaset was essentially an entertainment network. Educational programming was minimal and newscasts arrived only in 1991, after Mediaset coverage had become almost universal.
- **Main empirical design.** The authors predict Mediaset signal strength in each municipality using the location and technical characteristics of 1,710 transmitters operating in 1985. They then relate early signal strength to later voting outcomes.
- **Identification idea.** The key variation comes from actual signal strength after controlling for hypothetical free-space signal strength, terrain characteristics, electoral-district fixed effects, and local-labor-market fixed effects. This uses idiosyncratic topographic obstruction rather than simple proximity to transmitters.
- **Main political result.** Municipalities with stronger early Mediaset signal gave higher vote shares to Berlusconi’s party, *Forza Italia*, when he first ran in 1994. The effect persists through 2008 and then appears in support for the Five Star Movement (M5S) in 2013.
- **Mechanism result.** The effect is concentrated among heavy TV-viewing cohorts: children and the elderly. Children exposed to entertainment TV later show lower cognitive skills and lower civic engagement. Elderly exposed viewers later become more attached to Mediaset news.
- **Interpretation.** Entertainment TV seems to have made viewers more receptive to populist messages rather than simply more right-wing. This explains why early exposure predicts both support for *Forza Italia* and later support for M5S.
- **Economic takeaway.** Media can shape politics even without overt political news. Entertainment content may affect political demand by changing cognitive sophistication, civic engagement, cultural codes, and susceptibility to simple populist rhetoric.

2 Incremental contribution of the paper

- **From news bias to entertainment effects.** The paper expands the media-politics literature beyond partisan news and asks whether non-informative entertainment content can influence later political outcomes.
- **A rare content separation.** Because early Mediaset had no newscasts and little educational content, the setting separates entertainment exposure from direct political information.

- **Long-run media effects.** The paper studies voting consequences almost a decade after differential exposure and then follows outcomes across roughly two decades of elections.
- **Signal-strength identification.** The paper adapts the Olken-style signal propagation design to Italian television. It uses actual signal strength, hypothetical free-space signal strength, and terrain controls to isolate residual geographic variation in reception quality.
- **New historical data.** The authors digitize Mediaset transmitter characteristics, TV programming schedules, movie quality measures, election returns, party texts, and combine these with survey data on attitudes and cognitive skills.
- **Mechanism depth.** The paper goes beyond documenting a voting effect. It tests cohort heterogeneity, cognitive outcomes, civic engagement, TV-news consumption, party-specific education/civic gradients, and political language.
- **Populism contribution.** The paper links entertainment TV to support for populist parties in general. The 2013 M5S result is important because it is hard to interpret as simple affection for Berlusconi or conventional right-wing ideology.
- **Political communication contribution.** The paper shows that Berlusconi and *Forza Italia* used a simpler communication style, which helps explain why entertainment-induced declines in sophistication could translate into electoral support.
- **Broader implication.** The results imply that cultural products and entertainment markets may affect political equilibria by shaping voters' habits, skills, and receptivity to rhetoric.

3 Institutional background and data

3.1 The rise of Mediaset

- Private TV broadcasting in Italy was banned until 1976, after which private channels could broadcast only locally.
- Berlusconi launched Canale 5 in 1980 and later acquired Italia 1 and Rete 4, combining them into Fininvest, later Mediaset.
- In 1985, Mediaset operated 1,710 transmitters and reached about one-half of the population with high-quality signal.
- Coverage expanded rapidly after the 1984–1985 regulatory shift. By 1987, Mediaset reached about 87% of the population, and by 1990 coverage reached about 98%.
- The early transmitter network was inherited from local stations rather than built from scratch with later electoral strategy in mind.

Interpretation: The historical rollout matters because it created cross-municipality differences in entertainment exposure before Berlusconi entered politics.

3.2 Mediaset content versus RAI content

- Mediaset broadcast more hours per day than the public broadcaster RAI, especially in the early 1980s.

- Mediaset programming was overwhelmingly entertainment and movies. RAI devoted much more airtime to news and educational programs.
- The authors digitize programming schedules from *Corriere della Sera* for the first week of each month from 1983 to 1987.
- Mediaset movies receive worse critic ratings than RAI movies and are less suitable for general audiences, especially in afternoon and prime-time slots when children could watch.

Interpretation: Mediaset did not simply add television access. It sharply increased exposure to low-information, low-education entertainment programming.

3.3 Political setting

- Berlusconi did not enter politics until late 1993, after corruption scandals dismantled Italy's old party system.
- His party, *Forza Italia*, first competed in the 1994 election.
- *Forza Italia* had a personalistic, outsider, anti-establishment style and used simple, accessible language.
- The paper follows lower-house election outcomes from 1976 through 2013.
- The post-1994 period allows the authors to examine the effect of pre-1985 entertainment exposure on Berlusconi's party and, later, on M5S.

Interpretation: The timing is crucial. Differential exposure occurred before Berlusconi's political entry, reducing the concern that the TV network was placed to maximize his future vote share.

3.4 Signal-strength data

- The authors obtain technical reports for Mediaset transmitters active in 1985, including latitude, longitude, altitude, height, power, and frequency.
- They combine transmitter data with high-resolution GIS information on Italy.
- The signal-strength measure comes from the Longley-Rice Irregular Terrain Model, which predicts electromagnetic signal loss using distance and topography.
- For each municipality-transmitter pair, the authors subtract signal loss from transmission power and define municipal signal strength as the maximum predicted signal over transmitters.
- The main variable, *Signal*, is the standardized actual signal strength. The key control, *SignalFree*, is standardized signal strength in a hypothetical world without geomorphological obstacles.

Interpretation: The empirical design compares places that were similarly targeted by transmitters in free space but differed in actual reception because of local topographic obstruction.

3.5 Individual-level mechanism data

- **ITANES.** The Italian National Election Study provides survey data on voting, political attitudes, media use, municipality of residence, age, gender, and other characteristics for waves between 1994 and 2013.
- **ISTAT time use.** A 1983 survey gives TV consumption by age group, showing that children and older individuals are heavy TV viewers.
- **Military records.** Restricted-use data on Italian male conscripts born between 1973 and 1978 provide psychometric measures of general intelligence.
- **PIAAC.** OECD adult numeracy and literacy tests provide additional cognitive-skill outcomes for respondents whose municipalities can be linked to 1985 Mediaset signal.
- **Political language data.** Party manifestos and TV-debate transcripts allow the authors to measure readability and use of common words.

Interpretation: The paper combines aggregate voting data with individual-level outcome data to distinguish several possible mechanisms.

4 Empirical specifications and identification

4.1 Baseline municipality specification

The main municipal regression can be written as

$$Vote_m = \beta Signal_m + \gamma SignalFree_m + \delta' X_m + ED_{i(m)} + LLM_{j(m)} + \varepsilon_m.$$

- $Vote_m$ is the vote share of a given party in municipality m .
- $Signal_m$ is actual Mediaset signal strength in 1985.
- $SignalFree_m$ is hypothetical signal strength without terrain obstacles.
- X_m includes surface area, altitude, terrain ruggedness, income, education, and population controls.
- Electoral-district and local-labor-market fixed effects absorb narrow-area political and economic differences.
- Regressions are weighted by 1981 population and standard errors are clustered by electoral district.

Interpretation: The coefficient β is a reduced-form effect of potential early exposure. It is not the effect of actual viewing because individual viewership is not observed in the municipal election data.

4.2 Balance and pre-trend logic

- The authors test whether 1985 Mediaset signal predicts pre-1994 political preferences.

- They regress 1976–1992 vote shares for the Italian Communist Party, Pentapartito, and other parties on signal strength.
- After fixed effects and controls, signal strength is not systematically related to pre-Mediaset political outcomes.
- They also test socioeconomic balance. Mediaset coverage is correlated with development in raw data, but most correlations disappear after controlling for free-space signal, geography, and fixed effects.
- Income and education remain correlated with signal and are therefore included in the main specifications.

Interpretation: The balance tests support, but do not prove, the claim that residual signal variation is plausibly unrelated to later voting except through TV exposure.

4.3 Robustness designs

- **Small municipalities.** The paper restricts the sample to progressively smaller municipalities. The political and commercial payoff from targeting very small places was low, so exposure there is closer to accidental.
- **Neighbor matching.** The paper compares neighboring municipalities with similar free-space signal but different actual signal. These municipalities are geographically close but differ in terrain-induced reception.
- **Alternative standard errors.** The paper reports robustness to different clustering and spatial-correlation assumptions in the appendix.

Interpretation: The robustness analysis asks whether the main effect is driven by targeted transmitter placement or broad regional differences. The estimates remain similar.

4.4 Individual-level specifications

For survey outcomes, the authors estimate specifications similar to

$$Y_{im} = \beta \text{Signal}_m + \gamma \text{SignalFree}_m + \delta' X_m + \theta \text{Age}_i + \lambda \text{Gender}_i + FE + u_{im},$$

where Y_{im} is a survey outcome for individual i in municipality m .

- ITANES regressions include province and election-year fixed effects.
- Mechanism regressions classify respondents by age in 1985.
- PIAAC and military-test regressions link current cognitive outcomes to historical signal strength.
- Standard errors are clustered at the municipality level for survey data.

Interpretation: These regressions test whether the voting results are stronger among heavier TV-consuming cohorts and whether exposure changed skills, civic engagement, and media habits.

5 Main results and interpretation

5.1 Early Mediaset exposure and *Forza Italia* in 1994

- A one-standard-deviation increase in 1985 Mediaset signal strength is associated with roughly a 0.85 percentage point increase in the 1994 vote share of *Forza Italia* in the fully controlled baseline specification.
- The effect is economically large because all municipalities eventually received Mediaset, so the coefficient reflects only a few additional years of exposure.
- The authors approximate that absent entertainment TV during the 1980s, *Forza Italia*'s vote share would have been about 1.5 percentage points lower.
- Parliamentary-seat calculations suggest the effect was large enough to matter for the distribution of seats in the 1994, 1996, and 2001 elections.

Interpretation: The first-order result is that early exposure to entertainment TV predicts later support for the owner of that entertainment network once he enters politics.

5.2 Persistence and the shift to M5S

- The positive effect on *Forza Italia* persists in 1994, 1996, 2001, 2006, and 2008.
- The effect on *Forza Italia* vanishes in 2013.
- In 2013, early-exposed municipalities show significantly higher support for M5S, a new populist party ideologically distinct from Berlusconi's party.
- Other parties do not show a similar positive pattern.

Interpretation: The 2013 result is central. It suggests that entertainment TV did not simply generate durable loyalty to Berlusconi, but instead increased receptivity to populist rhetoric more generally.

5.3 Populist attitudes, not generic right-wing values

- Individual-level ITANES data confirm that early exposure predicts voting for *Forza Italia*.
- Early-exposed individuals are more likely to agree that politics is too complicated, that politicians only want votes, and that immigrants steal jobs.
- Early-exposed individuals are not more likely to hold traditional right-wing positions on abortion, same-sex couples, or common-law marriage.

Interpretation: The attitudinal evidence points toward anti-establishment and populist views rather than a broad ideological move to the right.

5.4 Age heterogeneity

- TV viewing by age is U-shaped: children and older individuals watch more TV than prime-age adults.
- The voting effect of early Mediaset exposure is concentrated among those below age 10 and those 55 or older in 1985.
- The estimated effects for these cohorts are much larger than the average individual-level effect.
- Middle-age groups show small and statistically weak effects.

Interpretation: The pattern lines up with exposure intensity. Entertainment TV matters most for people who actually watched a lot of TV.

5.5 Mechanisms for children

- Children exposed to Mediaset before age 10 perform worse on adult cognitive outcomes.
- Military records show lower general intelligence scores and a higher probability of being exempted because of low psychometric scores.
- PIAAC data show lower adult numeracy and literacy among those exposed as children.
- ITANES data show lower adult interest in politics and lower membership in voluntary associations.

Interpretation: Early entertainment TV appears to reduce cognitive sophistication and civic engagement. This can make voters more vulnerable to simple, anti-establishment political messages.

5.6 Mechanisms for older viewers

- Older individuals exposed to Mediaset in 1985 become more likely to watch Mediaset news after newscasts are introduced in 1991.
- This mechanism is different from the child mechanism. The elderly effect works through channel attachment and later exposure to pro-Berlusconi news.
- The paper therefore distinguishes a long-run developmental channel for children from a media-habit channel for older viewers.

Interpretation: The same entertainment shock can operate through different channels depending on age at first exposure.

5.7 Why populist parties benefit

- Parties that are less popular among educated and civic-minded voters are the parties that gain more from Mediaset exposure.
- *Forza Italia* and M5S fit this pattern.

- Berlusconi and *Forza Italia* use more readable language and more common words than other parties and politicians.
- Early-exposed viewers do not simply know Berlusconi better or rate him more positively as a person or statesman.

Interpretation: Entertainment TV creates a voter pool more receptive to simple populist rhetoric. Berlusconi’s party was well positioned to benefit in 1994–2008, and M5S was well positioned to benefit in 2013.

6 Tables and figures

6.1 Figure 1: Total airtime and content categories

Read:

- Panel A shows that Mediaset broadcast substantially more hours per day than RAI throughout 1983–1987.
- Panel B shows that Mediaset concentrated on entertainment and movies, while RAI devoted much more airtime to educational programming and news.
- Mediaset therefore expanded the entertainment supply rather than the supply of political information.

Economic message: The treatment is not simply television access. It is exposure to a commercial entertainment diet that differs sharply from public-service broadcasting.

6.2 Figure 2: Movie quality and parental suitability

Read:

- Mediaset movies receive lower critic ratings than RAI movies.
- Mediaset movies are less likely to be suitable for general audiences, particularly in afternoon and prime-time programming.
- These patterns reinforce the interpretation that early Mediaset was entertainment-heavy and lower in educational quality.

Economic message: The content mechanism is plausible because Mediaset changed not just the quantity but also the nature and quality of TV consumption.

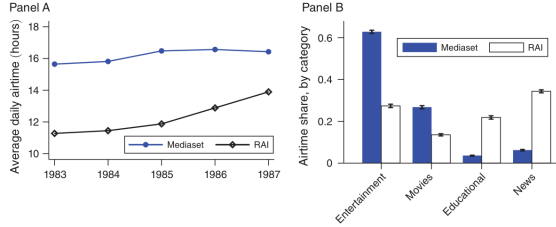


FIGURE 1. TOTAL AIRTIME PER DAY AND AIRTIME SHARES FOR DIFFERENT CATEGORIES OF TV SHOWS, MEDIASET VERSUS RAI, 1983–1987

Notes: Panel A plots the average total airtime per day on Mediaset and RAI channels over the period 1983–1987. Panel B shows the average share of airtime (and associated 90 percent confidence intervals) devoted to different categories of TV programs on the two networks.

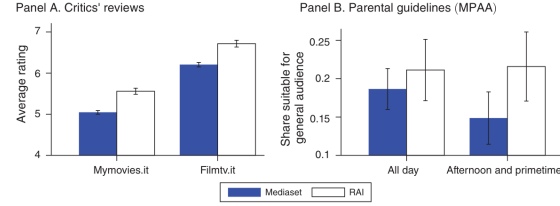


FIGURE 2. CRITICS' REVIEWS AND PARENTAL GUIDELINES FOR MOVIES BROADCAST ON MEDIASET AND RAI, 1983–1987

Notes: Panel A plots the average critics' ratings received by movies broadcast on Mediaset and RAI over the period 1983–1987. Panel B shows the share of movies suitable for general audiences, including children, according to the Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA). Ninety-percent confidence intervals are also shown in the graphs.

(a) Figure 1: Airtime and content categories

(b) Figure 2: Movie quality and parental guidelines

6.3 Figure 3: Timeline of events

Read:

- The figure places the expansion of Mediaset before the 1994 political entry of Berlusconi.
- Mediaset coverage reaches 52% by 1985, 87% by 1987, and 98% by 1990.
- Newscasts begin in 1991, after near-universal coverage.

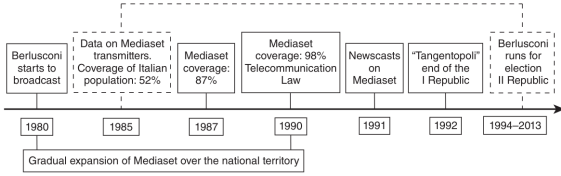
Economic message: The timing supports the identification argument: differential entertainment exposure predates Berlusconi's political campaign and the start of Mediaset news.

6.4 Figure 4: Actual and hypothetical signal strength

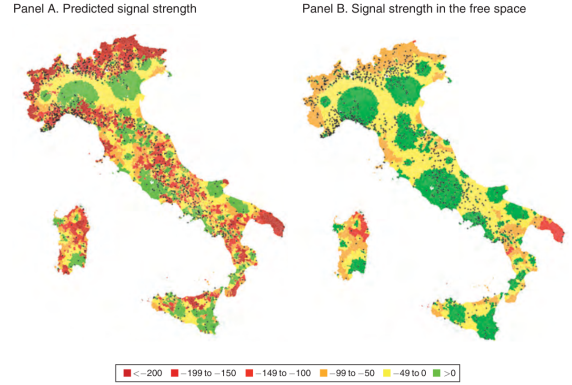
Read:

- Panel A maps actual predicted Mediaset signal strength across municipalities in 1985.
- Panel B maps signal strength in free space, abstracting from mountains and geomorphological obstacles.
- The difference between the two maps is the key source of identifying variation.

Economic message: The paper does not simply compare cities close and far from transmitters. It compares places with different reception after conditioning on transmitter placement and free-space signal.



(a) Figure 3: Timeline of Mediaset and politics



(b) Figure 4: Actual signal and free-space signal

6.5 Table 1: Balance tests using pre-1994 voting

Read:

- The table relates 1985 signal strength to vote shares of major parties before Berlusconi entered politics.
- After fixed effects and controls, coefficients are generally small and statistically insignificant.
- Signal strength does not predict changes in party vote shares from 1979 to 1983.

Economic message: Early Mediaset signal is not systematically related to pre-existing political preferences once the empirical controls are included.

6.6 Table 2: Balance tests using municipality characteristics

Read:

- Raw signal is correlated with several development measures, which is expected because early TV expansion reached more developed areas.
- After controlling for free-space signal, terrain, ED fixed effects, and LLM fixed effects, most correlations shrink sharply.
- Some correlation remains with education and income, so the main regressions include these controls.

Economic message: The table shows why the full control set is necessary. The identifying variation is not random in raw data but becomes much cleaner after geographic and fixed-effect controls.

TABLE 1—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND VOTING FOR THE MAIN ITALIAN PARTIES, 1976–1992 (BALANCE TESTS)

Party, election	Mean (1)	Univariate OLS		FE and controls	
		Coefficient (2)	R^2 (3)	Coefficient (4)	R^2 (5)
Italian Communist Party, 1976	33.332 (0.137)	1.773 (1.157)	0.005	-0.522 (0.574)	0.806
Pentapartito, 1976	54.95 (0.131)	-0.487 (1.068)	0.005	0.229 (0.508)	0.806
Other parties, 1976	9.027 (0.082)	-1.013 (1.047)	0.007	0.263 (0.248)	0.915
Italian Communist Party, 1979	28.966 (0.138)	1.644 (1.165)	0.002	-0.646 (0.535)	0.830
Pentapartito, 1979	55.153 (0.128)	-0.770 (1.105)	0.001	0.386 (0.476)	0.813
Other parties, 1979	11.672 (0.081)	-0.487 (1.006)	0.009	0.223 (0.236)	0.912
Italian Communist Party, 1983	28.003 (0.138)	1.502 (1.212)	0.002	-0.695 (0.559)	0.829
Pentapartito, 1983	53.607 (0.126)	-0.872 (1.166)	0.005	0.388 (0.483)	0.808
Other parties, 1983	12.522 (0.082)	-0.285 (0.984)	0.020	0.288 (0.272)	0.902
Italian Communist Party, 1987	25.223 (0.133)	0.847 (1.140)	0.002	-0.715 (0.510)	0.838
Pentapartito, 1987	54.73 (0.128)	-1.187 (1.225)	0.001	0.417 (0.458)	0.829
Other parties, 1987	15.056 (0.088)	0.681 (0.999)	0.007	0.258 (0.262)	0.913
Italian Communist Party, 1992	15.171 (0.105)	0.410 (0.859)	0.000	-0.078 (0.365)	0.862
Pentapartito, 1992	50.586 (0.145)	-3.031 (1.562)	0.007	-0.210 (0.409)	0.891
Other parties, 1992	28.773 (0.136)	2.997 (1.454)	0.007	0.283 (0.252)	0.942
Italian Communist Party, change 1979–1983	-0.963 (0.026)	-0.129 (0.140)	0.000	-0.033 (0.113)	0.499
Pentapartito, change 1979–1983	-1.54 (0.038)	-0.102 (0.224)	0.018	-0.004 (0.187)	0.566
Other parties, change 1979–1983	0.851 (0.029)	0.199 (0.167)	0.021	0.059 (0.147)	0.703

Notes: The table explores the relationship between early access to Mediaset and the average vote shares of the main parties and coalitions in each national election between 1976 and 1992, as well as the change in vote shares between the 1979 and the 1983 elections, the last ones prior to the diffusion of Mediaset (last three rows). Column 1 reports the mean of each variable; columns 2 and 3 report the coefficient and R^2 of the univariate OLS regression of each variable on Mediaset signal strength in 1985 (*Signal*) controlling for signal strength in the free space (*SignalFree*); columns 4 and 5 add ED and LLM fixed effects, surface area and its square, average altitude and its square, and average terrain ruggedness. Means and regressions are weighted by municipality population in 1981, heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the electoral district level are reported in parentheses.

(a) Table 1: Voting balance tests

TABLE 2—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND MUNICIPALITY CHARACTERISTICS (BALANCE TESTS)

	Mean (1)	Univariate OLS		FE and controls	
		Coefficient (2)	R^2 (3)	Coefficient (4)	R^2 (5)
Population, thousands (1981)	6.936 (0.579)	68.164 (63.342)	0.249	8.983 (7.446)	0.999
Population, thousands (change 1981–2001)	-0.713 (5.258)	-0.963 (6.111)	0.020	-0.159 (0.653)	0.994
log income per capita, thousand euros (1985)	1.738 (0.024)	0.110 (0.035)	0.039	0.025 (0.008)	0.913
Higher education, percentage (1981)	13.183 (0.708)	1.411 (0.690)	0.144	0.723 (0.234)	0.833
Voluntary associations $\times$ 100 inhabitants (1981)	0.103 (0.004)	-0.001 (0.007)	0.032	0.003 (0.004)	0.497
Activity rate, percentage (1991)	42.258 (0.220)	2.535 (0.278)	0.047	0.137 (0.151)	0.858
Employment rate, percentage (1991)	35.074 (0.419)	3.155 (0.564)	0.021	0.135 (0.160)	0.953
Unemployment rate, percentage (1991)	6.936 (0.202)	-0.855 (0.357)	0.005	-0.121 (0.173)	0.791
Firms per 1,000 inhabitants (1981)	50.927 (1.125)	0.765 (1.256)	0.043	-0.046 (0.653)	0.724
Firms per 1,000 inhabitants (change 1971–1981)	10.182 (0.553)	0.441 (0.838)	0.023	0.062 (0.530)	0.570
Firms' employees, thousands (1981)	78.1 (34.715)	27.163 (25.878)	0.195	2.594 (2.169)	0.999
Firms' employees, thousands (change 1971–1981)	2.717 (4.019)	-1.434 (2.883)	0.096	0.111 (0.095)	0.998

Notes: The table reports the mean of municipality characteristics (column 1) and their correlation with early exposure to Mediaset (columns 2 and 3). Specifically, columns 2 and 3 report the coefficient and R^2 of the univariate OLS regression of each variable on Mediaset signal strength in 1985 (*Signal*) controlling for signal strength in the free space (*SignalFree*); in columns 4 and 5 we add ED and LLM fixed effects, surface area and its square, average altitude and its square, and average terrain ruggedness. Means and regressions are weighted by municipality population in 1981 (with the exception of mean population and population growth). Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the electoral district level are reported in parentheses.

(b) Table 2: Municipality-characteristic balance tests

6.7 Table 3: Baseline effect on *Forza Italia* in 1994

Read:

- The univariate coefficient on signal is 2.853, but the controlled baseline coefficient is 0.851.
- The coefficient remains positive and significant after adding free-space signal, geographic controls, ED and LLM fixed effects, income, education, and electorate size.
- The no-weight and winsorized specifications produce similar results.

Economic message: Early entertainment exposure predicts support for Berlusconi's party in the first election after he entered politics.

6.8 Table 4: Robustness for 1994 results

Read:

- Dropping province capitals and progressively excluding large municipalities leaves the coefficient close to the baseline.
- Neighbor-matching estimates remain positive when exposed municipalities are compared with

nearby municipalities with similar free-space signal.

- The point estimates are similar to the baseline even in smaller and more restrictive samples.

Economic message: The main effect is unlikely to be driven only by targeted coverage of large or politically valuable cities.

TABLE 3—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND VOTING FOR *FORZA ITALIA* IN 1994

	Baseline regression					No weights Winsor.	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)
<i>Signal</i>	2.853 (0.860)	3.215 (0.705)	3.666 (0.759)	0.901 (0.232)	0.851 (0.234)	0.976 (0.193)	0.729 (0.218)
<i>SignalFree</i>		-0.289 (0.719)	0.014 (0.473)	-0.668 (0.260)	-0.642 (0.254)	-0.396 (0.202)	-0.433 (0.234)
Area (100s km ²)			-0.966 (0.695)	0.854 (0.380)	0.875 (0.404)	0.540 (0.335)	0.780 (0.408)
Area ²			0.030 (0.054)	-0.079 (0.093)	-0.069 (0.093)	-0.033 (0.084)	-0.043 (0.095)
Altitude (thousands meters)			-6.244 (4.483)	-12.716 (1.578)	-10.963 (1.625)	-9.675 (1.373)	-9.771 (1.619)
Altitude ²			-0.092 (3.953)	7.125 (1.269)	6.367 (1.290)	5.259 (1.218)	5.239 (1.256)
Ruggedness			0.007 (0.004)	-0.002 (0.001)	-0.002 (0.001)	-0.002 (0.001)	-0.003 (0.001)
Electorate (thousands)					-0.004 (0.004)	0.003 (0.005)	-0.005 (0.004)
log income per capita (thousands euros)					5.109 (0.763)	4.760 (0.614)	5.017 (0.743)
Education (% high-school + college)					-0.089 (0.030)	-0.108 (0.032)	-0.093 (0.029)
Observations	7,600	7,600	7,590	7,590	7,519	7,519	7,898
Electoral district fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Local labor market fixed effects	No	No	No	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
R ²	0.051	0.051	0.109	0.919	0.921	0.765	0.920

Notes: The table reports OLS estimates of the effect of early exposure to Mediaset on the vote share of *Forza Italia* in the 1994 elections. The main explanatory variable, *Signal*, is Mediaset signal strength in 1985; *SignalFree* is signal strength in the free space. *Area*, *Altitude*, *Area²*, and *Altitude²* are the municipality's surface (in squared meters) and average altitude (in thousand meters) and their respective squared terms; *Ruggedness* is the municipality's average terrain ruggedness; *Electorate* is the number of eligible voters in the municipality, in thousands; *log income per capita* is the logarithm of per capita income in 1985; *Education* is the share of municipality population with at least a high-school diploma. The specifications in columns 4 through 7 also include ED and LLM fixed effects. All regressions except column 6 are weighted by municipality population in 1981. In column 7 we winsorize *Signal* rather than trimming the sample like in the other specifications. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the electoral district level are reported in parentheses.

TABLE 4—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND VOTING FOR *FORZA ITALIA* IN 1994, ROBUSTNESS

	Baseline estimate (1)	Only smaller municipalities				Matching neighbors		
		No prov. cap. (2)	Pop. ≤ 100K (3)	Pop. ≤ 50K (4)	Pop. ≤ 10K (5)	Δ ≤ 1 (6)	Δ ≤ 0.5 (7)	Δ ≤ 0.25 (8)
<i>Signal</i>	0.851 (0.234)	0.817 (0.226)	0.763 (0.231)	0.817 (0.232)	0.880 (0.219)	0.584 (0.161)	0.750 (0.188)	0.834 (0.229)
Observations	7,519	7,415	7,474	7,397	6,582	4,548	3,229	2,071
R ²	0.921	0.894	0.895	0.884	0.829	0.854	0.840	0.818

Notes: This table compares the estimated effect of early exposure to Mediaset on the vote share of *Forza Italia* in the 1994 elections within different subsamples. Column 1 reproduces the baseline regression in column 5 of Table 3. Columns 2 to 5 restrict the sample to progressively smaller municipalities, indicated on top of each column. Columns 6 to 8 include in the sample only pairs of neighboring municipalities such that $|SignalFree_i - SignalFree_j| < \Delta$ and $Signal_i < 0 \leq Signal_j$ for different values of Δ , indicated on top of each column. All regressions control on the right-hand side for all municipality-level variables reported in column 5 of Table 3, namely *SignalFree*, *Area*, *Altitude*, *Area*, *Altitude²*, *Ruggedness*, *Electorate*, *log income per capita*, *Education*. Regressions in columns 1 to 5 control in addition for ED and LLM fixed effects; heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the electoral district level are reported in parentheses. Regressions in columns 6 to 8 control instead for neighbor-pair fixed effects (each municipality can appear in more than one pair); heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are clustered at the municipality level.

(a) Table 3: Baseline 1994 effect

(b) Table 4: Robustness across samples and matched neighbors

6.9 Figure 5: Robustness graphically

Read:

- Panel A shows that the effect is stable when restricting the sample to smaller municipalities.
- Panel B shows that the effect remains under stricter neighbor comparisons and changes in the signal cutoff.
- The sample size falls as the design becomes more restrictive, but the point estimates remain positive.

Economic message: The visual robustness evidence reinforces the table-based claim that the effect is not an artifact of the broad geography of Mediaset expansion.

6.10 Table 5: Main parties and elections, 1994–2013

Read:

- The coefficient on *Forza Italia* is positive and statistically significant from 1994 through 2008.

- By 2013, the *Forza Italia* coefficient is small and insignificant.
- In 2013, M5S has a positive and significant coefficient of 0.522.
- Other parties generally do not show the same positive pattern.

Economic message: The persistence is not just a short-run campaign effect. The M5S result shifts the interpretation from pro-Berlusconi loyalty to broader populist receptivity.

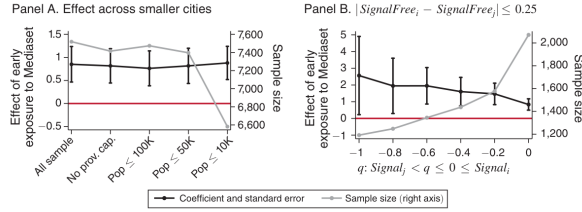


FIGURE 5. EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND VOTING FOR *FORZA ITALIA* IN 1994, ROBUSTNESS

Notes: This figure compares the estimated effect of early exposure to Mediaset on the vote share of *Forza Italia* in the 1994 elections within different subsamples. Panel A shows the coefficient of *Signal* (and associated confidence intervals) from the baseline regression in column 5 of Table 3, when restricting the sample to progressively smaller municipalities, indicated on the horizontal axis. Panel B shows the coefficient of *Signal* (and associated confidence intervals) from the regression in column 8 of Table 4 (i.e., including in the sample only pairs of neighboring municipalities such that $|SignalFree_i - SignalFree_j| \leq 0.25$ and $Signal_j < q \leq 0 \leq Signal_i$) for different values of q , indicated on the horizontal axis. Both graphs also show (on the right vertical axis) the sample size in each regression.

(a) Figure 5: Robustness plots

TABLE 5—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND VOTING FOR MAIN POLITICAL PARTIES, 1994–2013

Election year:	1994	1996	2001	2006	2008	2013
<i>Party</i>						
Forza Italia	0.851 (0.234)	0.713 (0.200)	0.832 (0.296)	0.945 (0.281)	1.021 (0.337)	0.198 (0.273)
Others centre-right	0.082 (0.361)	0.006 (0.318)	-0.121 (0.218)	0.034 (0.204)	-0.194 (0.144)	-0.091 (0.088)
Centrist parties	-0.183 (0.264)	-0.239 (0.158)	-0.186 (0.197)	-0.002 (0.147)	-0.237 (0.168)	0.079 (0.136)
Democrat Party	-0.407 (0.376)	-0.473 (0.327)	-0.422 (0.285)	-0.483 (0.372)	-0.644 (0.342)	-0.421 (0.271)
Others centre-left	-0.183 (0.124)	-0.041 (0.151)	-0.075 (0.196)	-0.265 (0.233)	-0.027 (0.108)	-0.103 (0.094)
Extreme left	-0.322 (0.152)	-0.227 (0.154)	-0.204 (0.160)	-0.212 (0.168)	-0.105 (0.087)	-0.219 (0.088)
M5S						0.522 (0.243)
Other parties	0.027 (0.198)	0.129 (0.092)	0.134 (0.097)	0.003 (0.073)	0.142 (0.177)	0.050 (0.179)
Invalid ballots	0.134 (0.128)	0.132 (0.136)	0.043 (0.171)	-0.020 (0.049)	0.044 (0.087)	-0.015 (0.069)
Turnout	0.338 (0.334)	0.488 (0.392)	0.369 (0.394)	0.260 (0.256)	0.212 (0.231)	0.512 (0.251)

Notes: The table shows the effect of early exposure to Mediaset on the vote share of the main Italian parties (rows) in each of the six elections held between 1994 and 2013 (columns). Each entry in the table reports the estimated coefficient (and standard error) of *Signal* from the baseline regression in column 5 of Table 3. Heteroskedasticity-

(b) Table 5: Elections and parties

6.11 Table 6: Political attitudes

Read:

- Early signal raises the probability of voting for *Forza Italia* by about 2.8 percentage points in individual-level survey data.
- It also predicts agreement with populist statements about politics, politicians, and immigrants.
- It does not predict traditional right-wing moral values.

Economic message: The survey evidence supports a populism channel rather than a conventional right-wing ideology channel.

6.12 Figure 6: TV consumption and age-specific effects

Read:

- TV consumption is highest among children and older people.
- The effect of early Mediaset exposure on voting is also strongest for those below 10 and those 55 or older in 1985.
- The age profile of consumption and the age profile of effects line up closely.

Economic message: The effect is strongest for cohorts that plausibly received more intense exposure.

TABLE 6—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND POLITICAL ATTITUDES

	Populist attitudes				Right-wing values		
	Voting for <i>Forza Italia</i> (1)	Politics is too complicated (2)	Politicians only want your vote (3)	Immigrants steal jobs (4)	Abortion should be made more difficult (5)	Same-sex couples should have same rights (6)	Common-law marriages should be recognized by law (7)
<i>Signal</i>	0.028 (0.012)	0.023 (0.015)	0.063 (0.023)	0.043 (0.019)	0.016 (0.018)	0.020 (0.021)	-0.019 (0.022)
Sample average	[0.21]	[0.80]	[0.70]	[0.46]	[0.43]	[0.59]	[0.77]
Observations	10,565	6,388	6,551	7,903	8,756	4,784	4,213
R^2	0.094	0.049	0.159	0.073	0.110	0.110	0.101

Notes: The table illustrates the effect of early exposure to Mediaset on individual political preferences, using survey data from various waves of the Italian National Election Study (ITANES) conducted between 1994 and 2013. The dependent variable in column 1 is a dummy equal to 1 for having voted for *Forza Italia* in the previous election; in columns 2 to 7 it is a dummy equal to 1 for individuals agreeing with the statements indicated on top of each column. The sample average of all dependent variables is reported in square brackets. The main explanatory variable, *Signal*, is Mediaset signal strength in 1985. All regressions also include on the right-hand side the following municipal controls: *SignalFree*, *Area*, *Altitude*, *Area²*, *Altitude²*, *log income per capita*, *Education* and *Population* 1981; plus province and election year fixed effects, and *Age* and *Gender* of the respondent. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the municipal level in parentheses.

(a) Table 6: Populist attitudes versus right-wing values

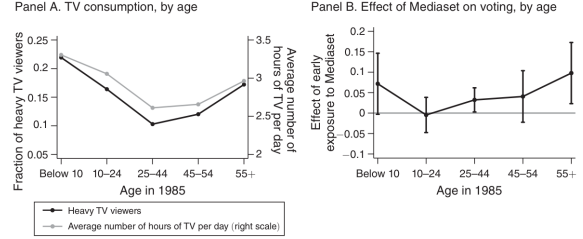


FIGURE 6. TV CONSUMPTION AND EFFECT OF EARLY EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET, BY COHORTS

Notes: Panel A depicts the share of heavy TV viewers (i.e., watching 5 hours or more of TV per day) and the average number of hours of TV per day for the same age groups. Panel B shows OLS estimates (and associated confidence intervals) of the effect of early exposure to Mediaset on the probability of voting for *Forza Italia* by age group, using the same classification as in online Appendix Table A7. The OLS specification is the same as in column 1 of Table 6.

(b) Figure 6: Age profile of TV consumption and effects

6.13 Table 7: Child exposure and military cognition outcomes

Read:

- Early exposure as a child lowers general intelligence scores in military psychometric tests.
- The effect becomes stronger when local-labor-market fixed effects are used.
- Early exposure increases the probability of being exempted because of very low general-intelligence scores.

Economic message: Entertainment TV exposure in childhood appears to have persistent effects on cognitive development, especially in the lower tail of test performance.

6.14 Table 8: Age-specific mechanisms

Read:

- For those below 10 in 1985, early exposure lowers PIAAC numeracy and literacy scores.
- The same group is less interested in politics and less likely to join voluntary associations.
- For those 55 or older in 1985, early exposure strongly predicts later watching of Mediaset news.

Economic message: The child effect works through cognitive and civic development; the elderly effect works through media attachment and later biased-news exposure.

	General intelligence score		Exempted (score = 1 or 2)	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
<i>Signal</i>	−0.023 (0.012)	−0.045 (0.018)	0.002 (0.001)	0.006 (0.002)
Sample average	[5.09]	[5.09]	[0.024]	[0.024]
Province fixed effects	Yes	No	Yes	No
Local labor market fixed effects	No	Yes	No	Yes
Observations	1,360,036	1,360,023	1,360,036	1,360,023
R^2	0.052	0.059	0.034	0.041

Notes: The table illustrates the effect of being exposed to entertainment TV as a child on adult cognitive skills, as measured by psychometric tests partly based on the Minnesota Multiphasic Personality Inventory (Hathaway and McKinley 1951). The tests were administered to all Italian males at the time of military conscription (i.e., turning 18 or a few years older). The sample includes all conscripts born in the period 1973–1978. The dependent variable in columns 1 and 2 is a “general intelligence” score ranging between 1 and 7; the dependent variable in columns 3 and 4 is a dummy equal to 1 for individuals exempted from service for scoring particularly low (1 or 2). The sample average of all dependent variables is reported in square brackets. The main explanatory variable, *Signal*, is Mediaset signal strength in 1985. All regressions also include on the right-hand side all municipal controls reported in Table 6, province or LLM fixed effects (odd and even columns, respectively), plus *Age*. Heteroskedasticity-robust

(a) Table 7: Military-test cognition outcomes

TABLE 8—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AT DIFFERENT AGES AND ADULT COGNITIVE SKILLS, CIVIC ENGAGEMENT, AND TV NEWS CONSUMPTION

	PIAAC		ITANES		
	Numeracy score (1)	Literacy score (2)	Interest in politics (3)	Membership of associations (4)	News on Mediaset (5)
Below 10	−16.820 (7.570)	−12.560 (7.390)	−0.147 (0.048)	−0.105 (0.049)	0.038 (0.064)
Age 10–24	−2.390 (5.570)	−0.790 (5.160)	0.008 (0.029)	0.013 (0.031)	0.032 (0.030)
Age 25–44	−2.170 (6.060)	−1.920 (5.300)	0.020 (0.018)	−0.038 (0.021)	0.006 (0.024)
Age 45–54		(0.050)	0.010 (0.049)	0.024 (0.050)	−0.007 (0.050)
55 or more		(0.053)	−0.033 (0.051)	−0.065 (0.070)	0.170 (0.0389)
Sample average	[252.9]	[256.4]	[0.355]	[0.355]	[0.389]

Notes: The table examines the effect of being exposed to entertainment TV at different ages (rows) on various individual outcomes in adulthood (columns). The age groups follow the same classification as in online Appendix Table A7 and refer to age in 1985. The sample in columns 1 and 2 includes all respondents to the Italian module of the OECD’s Program for the International Assessment of Adults Competencies (PIAAC) survey, conducted in 2012. The dependent variables are the scores obtained in the *Numeracy* (column 1) and *Literacy* (column 2) part of the PIAAC tests. The sample in columns 3 to 5 includes individuals interviewed in the context of the Italian National

(b) Table 8: Cognitive skills, civic engagement, and news consumption

6.15 Figure 7: Robustness for individual-level outcomes

Read:

- The figure repeats individual-level outcomes after excluding progressively larger municipalities.
- Voting, intelligence, numeracy, literacy, voluntary association membership, and political interest effects remain broadly stable.
- Some confidence intervals widen as the sample becomes smaller.

Economic message: The mechanism results are not driven only by large municipalities or province capitals.

6.16 Figure 8: Education, civic engagement, and party support

Read:

- The figure compares party-specific Mediaset effects with party-specific education and civic-engagement gradients.
- Parties that do worse among educated and civic-minded voters gain more from Mediaset exposure.
- *Forza Italia* and M5S are located in the part of the graph consistent with benefiting from reduced sophistication and civic engagement.

Economic message: The figure connects the mechanism to party competition: entertainment TV helps parties whose messages appeal more to less educated and less civic-minded voters.

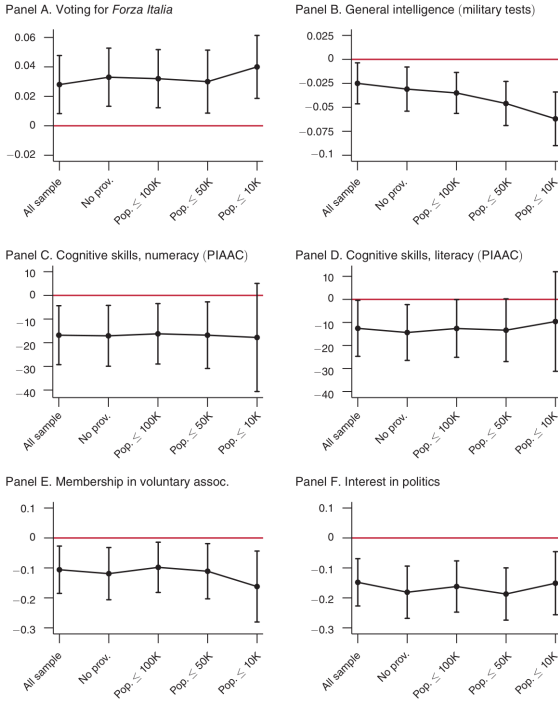


FIGURE 7. EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND INDIVIDUAL-LEVEL OUTCOMES, ROBUSTNESS

Note: These graphs show the estimated effect of *Signal* on individual-level outcomes (and associated confidence

(a) Figure 7: Individual-level robustness

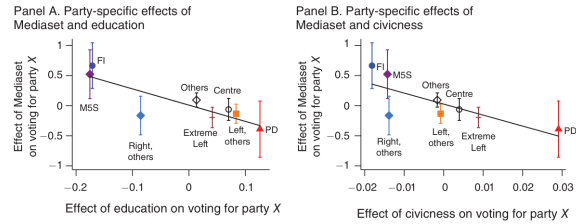


FIGURE 8. THE EFFECT OF EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET, EDUCATION, AND CIVIC ENGAGEMENT ON PARTIES' ELECTORAL SUPPORT

Notes: The figure illustrates the relationship between the effect of exposure to Mediaset (and associated confidence intervals) and the effects of education and civic engagement, respectively, on support for the main parties of the Second Republic. In particular, panels A and B plot the coefficient of *Signal* (y-axis) against, respectively, the coefficients of schooling levels and civic engagement in 1981 (x-axis). The coefficients are obtained from estimating equation (1) separately for each party, pooling together results of all elections and including year fixed effects.

(b) Figure 8: Education, civic engagement, and party effects

6.17 Table 9: Readability of party manifestos and TV debates

Read:

- *Forza Italia* manifestos have higher Gulpease readability scores than other party manifestos.
- Berlusconi's TV-debate language uses more commonly used words than the language of other politicians.
- The result remains after year fixed effects and right-wing controls.

Economic message: Berlusconi's political communication was unusually accessible. This helps explain why a decline in cognitive sophistication could translate into support for his party.

6.18 Table 10: Opinions about Berlusconi

Read:

- Early exposure does not significantly predict knowing Berlusconi in 1994.
- It does not systematically improve opinions about his qualifications, honesty, sincerity, trustworthiness, or statesmanship.
- The overall rating coefficient is also statistically weak.

Economic message: The mechanism is not simply name recognition or personal admiration. It is more consistent with a change in political receptivity and values.

TABLE 9—READABILITY OF PARTY MANIFESTOS AND COMMUNICATION STYLES IN TV DEBATES

	Party manifestos			TV debates		
	Gulpease Index			Percent of commonly used words		
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
<i>Forza Italia</i>	5.962 (1.319)	5.260 (1.593)	5.212 (2.019)	2.465 (0.816)	2.319 (0.613)	3.263 (0.989)
Right-wing			0.065 (1.426)			−1.250 (1.158)
Observations	34	34	34	37	37	37
Number of words	648,357	648,357	648,357	290,014	290,014	290,014
Year fixed effects	No	Yes	Yes	No	Yes	Yes
R^2	0.260	0.467	0.467	0.261	0.545	0.565

Notes: The table shows differences in the communication style of Berlusconi and its party, *Forza Italia*, compared to the other political leaders and parties in Italy. The dependent variable in columns 1 to 3 is the Gulpease Index, a standard measure of text readability, computed on the electoral manifestos issued by the main Italian parties before all general elections since 1983. The dependent variable in columns 4 to 6 is the share of commonly used words used by the main Italian politicians in relevant TV appearances since 1989 (online Appendix E provides additional details). The main explanatory variable is a dummy equal to 1 for the electoral manifestos issued by *Forza Italia* (columns 1–3) and TV appearances of Berlusconi (columns 4–6). Specifications in columns 2–3 and 5–6 include year fixed effects, and specifications 3 and 6 also include a dummy for right-wing parties and leaders, respectively. Observations are weighted by the number of words in each party manifesto and TV debate, respectively, and the total number of words is reported at the bottom of the table. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors are reported in parentheses.

(a) Table 9: Readability and communication style

TABLE 10—EXPOSURE TO MEDIASET AND OPINIONS ABOUT BERLUSCONI

	Done most for Italy (1993) (1)	Don't know him (1994) (2)	Qualified (3)	Honest (4)	Coherent (5)	Sincere (6)	Trustworthy (7)	Statesman (8)	Rating [1–10] (9)
<i>Signal</i>	0.075 (0.068)	−0.001 (0.017)	0.010 (0.030)	0.001 (0.017)	−0.046 (0.042)	−0.031 (0.042)	0.045 (0.026)	−0.029 (0.043)	0.076 (0.068)
Sample average	[0.132]	[0.094]	[0.619]	[0.352]	[0.626]	[0.581]	[0.518]	[0.629]	[5.37]
Observations	519	2,556	4,761	7,766	2,632	2,551	4,840	2,630	13,584

Notes: The table illustrates the effect of early exposure to Mediaset on knowledge and opinions about Berlusconi. The sample used in column 1 includes individuals surveyed in the context of a poll conducted by SWG in 1993. For the remaining columns the sample includes individuals interviewed in the context of the Italian National Election Study (ITANES) surveys conducted between 1994 and 2013. The dependent variable is a dummy for whether the respondent mentioned Berlusconi as one of the public figures who had done most for Italy in 1993 (column 1), a dummy for whether the respondent did not know who Berlusconi was (column 2), a dummy for whether the respondents believed Berlusconi to possess a specific quality (columns 3 to 8), and the overall rating on a 1–10 scale (column 9). The sample average of all dependent variables is reported in square brackets. Each entry reports the estimated coefficient (and corresponding standard error) of *Signal* from a regression including province fixed effects, election year fixed effects, all municipal controls reported in Table 6, and *Gender* and *Age* of the respondent. Heteroskedasticity-robust standard errors clustered at the municipal level in parentheses.

(b) Table 10: Knowledge and opinions about Berlusconi

7 Short summary

- The paper studies the long-run political effects of entertainment TV in Italy.
- The empirical setting is the staggered rollout of Berlusconi’s Mediaset network in the early 1980s.
- Mediaset was entertainment-heavy before newscasts started in 1991.
- The main treatment is predicted 1985 Mediaset signal strength, constructed using transmitter data and the Longley-Rice propagation model.
- The key identification compares actual signal strength after controlling for free-space signal, terrain, and narrow-area fixed effects.
- Early Mediaset exposure increases the 1994 vote share of *Forza Italia* and the effect persists through 2008.
- In 2013, the effect shifts to M5S, suggesting a broader populist mechanism.
- Individual-level evidence shows that early exposure predicts populist attitudes but not traditional right-wing moral values.
- The effect is concentrated among children and the elderly, the cohorts with the highest TV consumption.
- Children exposed to Mediaset later show lower cognitive skills and lower civic engagement.
- Older viewers exposed to Mediaset become more likely to watch Mediaset news after 1991.
- Parties that benefit from Mediaset are those more popular among less educated and less civic-minded voters.
- Berlusconi and *Forza Italia* used simpler, more accessible language than other politicians and parties.

- The paper’s main contribution is to show that entertainment media can have durable political consequences even before explicit political news is introduced.

8 Conclusion

8.1 Core conclusion

Durante, Pinotti, and Tesei show that early exposure to commercial entertainment TV in Italy had persistent political consequences. Municipalities with stronger Mediaset signal before 1985 later gave more support to Berlusconi’s *Forza Italia*, and this effect lasted for five elections. When the effect on *Forza Italia* disappeared, the same exposure predicted support for M5S, another populist movement.

8.2 Economic intuition

The central intuition is that entertainment media can change voters even without delivering overt political content. Light entertainment can crowd out educational and civic activities, shape cultural codes, and habituate viewers to simpler communication. If voters become less cognitively sophisticated or less civically engaged, they may become more receptive to personalistic and anti-establishment political messages.

8.3 Incremental contribution revisited

The paper advances the literature in three main ways. First, it moves beyond biased news to show that non-news entertainment can affect politics. Second, it uses transmitter-level signal data and topographic variation to create a credible reduced-form exposure design. Third, it provides a mechanism analysis linking entertainment exposure to cognitive skills, civic engagement, news habits, populist attitudes, and political language.

8.4 Implications

The results imply that media regulation and media-market structure can influence politics through slow-moving cultural and developmental channels. The political consequences of television are not limited to campaign coverage or partisan news. Entertainment programming may shape the kinds of political messages that voters find compelling.

8.5 Limitations

The design identifies reduced-form effects of potential exposure, not actual viewership. It cannot fully separate every feature of entertainment content, such as advertising, pacing, violence, and program quality. The setting is also distinctive: Berlusconi owned the entertainment network and later entered politics. Finally, some mechanism tests rely on survey data and cross-cohort comparisons that are informative but not equivalent to a randomized exposure experiment.

8.6 Takeaway

The enduring takeaway is that entertainment media can leave a political legacy. By changing cognitive development, civic habits, and responsiveness to simple populist rhetoric, a commercial TV network can shape electoral outcomes long after the initial exposure.